

Typographic Archives of Latino Life: New Media Alphabets in Southwestern Ontario

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Working title

Typographic Archives of Latino Life: New Media Alphabets in Southwestern Ontario

Working central question

How can a co-designed expanded Latin character set developed with Latino residents along the London-Sarnia corridor document everyday life, challenge dominant assumptions about typographic quality, and support ethical forms of visibility and representation?

Project summary

This thesis is a research-creation project about typography, Latino life, memory, place, material process, and ethical representation in Southwestern Ontario. It proposes the development of a co-designed expanded Latin character set with Latino participants who live, work, commute, study, worship, shop, organize, and build community along the London-Sarnia corridor. The project treats typography not only as a formal design output, but also as a method of listening, collecting, translating, testing, drawing, and making visible situated forms of experience.

The project has developed through six interconnected areas of exploration: typography as archive; who defines good typography; typographic mechanics and expanded Latin character set construction; ethical visibility; corridor life as visual ecology; and traditional printing processes as methods of expression. Together, these areas allow the thesis to move between theory, form, method, material process, craft knowledge, and lived geography. The character set becomes a site where stories, vernacular signs, migration memories, labour routes, storefront graphics, domestic objects, handwritten marks, devotional images, transit rhythms, digital communication, and printmaking processes can be studied through design.

A central part of the project is the development of the expanded Latin character set as a working typographic system. This process will involve studying typographic mechanics such as stroke logic, contrast, rhythm, spacing, proportion, weight, scale, hierarchy, texture, kerning, and the relationship between individual glyphs and the full system. Participant references, conversations, visual materials, and mapped experiences will inform the formal decisions of the work. These references will then be translated into sketches, digital drawings, proofs, and revised letterforms. The goal is not to create a decorative “Latino style,” but to build a situated typographic language that emerges from

participant-informed research, shared authorship, and careful formal testing.

The character set will be developed through type design workflows using typographic-making software, font files, digital proofing, and, where useful, code-based testing. These tools will support drawing, spacing, refinement, proof generation, specimen design, variation, and documentation. The technical process matters because the project is not only making images of letters. It is building and testing a font as a working typographic system across print, screen, motion, exhibition, and archive.

Traditional printing and letterpress processes are also central to the proposal. In addition to digital type design, font production, variable testing, specimens, proofs, and motion experiments, the thesis will produce printed posters using the co-designed character set. These works will be developed through supervised printmaking processes that include relief printing, editioning, registration, and material documentation. This stage transforms the character set from a digital font into a physical, reproducible form, allowing the project to test how type changes through impression, texture, scale, repetition, and public exhibition.

This connection to traditional printing also comes from my family history. My family has owned and worked with print shops for more than three generations, which gives this project a personal relationship to printing, labour, craft knowledge, and material production. In this sense, traditional printing is not only a production method. It becomes a way of thinking through ancestry, labour, touch, and memory. The poster becomes a material archive where each letter carries traces of process, place, and cultural continuity.

This thesis therefore understands typography as a knowledge-making practice. It asks how type can act as archive, testimony, public voice, cultural memory, and technical system at the same time. It also asks how design can be accountable to the people, histories, materials, tools, and places that shape it. Through co-design, type mechanics, font production, traditional printing processes, and reflexive writing, the project positions the expanded Latin character set as both a cultural archive and a working typographic system.

Section 01: Abstract. Description of the project

Typographic Archives of Latino Life: New Media Alphabets in Southwestern Ontario is a research-creation thesis that explores how typography can document everyday Latino life through a co-designed expanded Latin character set, material experimentation, and ethical representation. The project focuses on Latino residents along the London-Sarnia corridor in Southwestern Ontario, a region shaped by migration, labour, commuting, storefronts, domestic life, service spaces, churches, schools, roads, and informal visual cultures.

The thesis treats typography as more than a formal design practice. It understands letterforms as carriers of memory, testimony, place, belonging, and cultural negotiation. At the same time, the project questions my own role as designer and researcher within this process. It asks how my decisions, methods, family history in print production, cultural position, and design training shape what is collected, translated, formalized, and made visible through typography.

The project asks how an expanded Latin character set can emerge from the lived experiences, visual references, and everyday environments of Latino participants without reducing those experiences to a fixed cultural style. This question requires attention to authorship, power, consent, interpretation, and accountability. The character set is not approached as a neutral design object, but as a site where memory, place, technical systems, and representation are produced through relationships.

The thesis will be developed through co-design, semi-structured conversations, visual mapping, participant-informed image collection, typographic sketching, type design, proofing, and traditional printing processes. The research focuses on an expanded Latin character set, exploring stroke, rhythm, spacing, proportion, hierarchy, texture, kerning, diacritics, and the relationship between individual glyphs and the full system. Typographic-making software will be used to generate, refine, and test the font as a working typographic system.

A central part of the project will be the production of printed posters and type specimens. These works will move the character set from digital form into physical presence, allowing the project to test how type changes through material process, reproduction, texture, and public exhibition. In this thesis, “new media alphabets” refers to typographic systems that move across digital, printed, motion-based, archival, and exhibition formats. New media is not treated only as screen-based technology, but as the circulation of letterforms across tools, materials, platforms, and publics.

Overall, the thesis argues that typography can become a critical knowledge-making practice: a way of studying memory, place, labour, visual culture, authorship, and representation through the construction of letters.

Section 02: Contents of the thesis

The thesis will have two major components: a research-creation exhibition and a written thesis paper. These two parts will support each other. The exhibition will make the research visible through typography, print, process, and installation. The paper will explain the conceptual, theoretical, methodological, and ethical framework of the work.

2.1 Exhibition component

The exhibition will present the project as an evolving typographic archive. It may include the following components:

A. Co-designed expanded Latin character set or type family

The project will develop an expanded Latin character set or type family through participant-informed research. It may include uppercase and lowercase letters, numerals, punctuation, diacritics, accented characters, and selected glyphs relevant to the visual and linguistic practices that appear in the research.

This character set will be shaped by conversations, observations, maps, objects, memories, signs, and design decisions. The project builds on my existing expertise in type design, expanded Latin character set construction, typographic systems, and material experimentation, including my previous *Otava* typeface project. *Otava* is not part of the final thesis outcome. It functions as a methodological precedent that demonstrates my experience with cultural references, monolinear construction, rhythm, modular forms, printmaking, variable workflows, and exhibition display.

The thesis character set will respond specifically to the London-Sarnia corridor and to the participants involved. The goal is not to apply a previous style to a new community, but to develop a situated typographic language through participant-informed research, typographic testing, and material process.

B. Traditional printing poster series

The poster series will be a key material outcome. The posters will translate the expanded Latin character set into

traditionally printed works through supervised printmaking processes. The series may include:

- A full character set poster showing the expanded Latin glyph set.
- A specimen poster showing spacing, accents, numerals, punctuation, and test words.
- A poster testing type weights across the character set.
- A corridor poster using place names, road references, routes, storefront fragments, or participant-informed words.
- Illustrative posters of participants, developed only with consent and participant review.
- A process poster documenting plate preparation, proofing, impression, registration, and material testing.
- A limited edition poster set, numbered and documented as part of the archive.

The posters will be produced under technician or expert printer supervision. Each stage will generate research evidence, including digital files, plate proofs, make-ready notes, proof sheets, rejected prints, registration tests, material tests, and final editions.

C. Type specimens and typographic tests

The exhibition may include type specimens that test the expanded Latin character set across multiple conditions:

- Character set display sheets.
- Paragraph settings.
- Participant-informed word or phrase samples.
- Accented character and diacritic tests.
- Spacing and rhythm studies.
- Large scale poster settings.
- Small scale text tests.
- Variable weight or style tests.
- Format and material comparisons.

These specimens will help connect the formal craft of typography to the research questions about quality, typographic meaning, cultural recognition, and material translation.

D. Process archive

The process archive will show the making of the work. It may include:

- Interview prompts and anonymized summaries.
- Visual mapping exercises.
- Sketches and letterform development.
- Glyph proofs.
- Spacing sheets.
- Variable font axis tests.
- UFO or designspace diagrams.
- Plate proofs and print tests.
- Screenprint or letterpress process documentation.
- Reflection notes.
- Consent and circulation decisions, shown in a careful and non-private way.

This section will communicate that the thesis is not only the final character set. It is also the process of making, testing, revising, and negotiating representation.

E. Motion or digital specimen

A digital component may show the character set in motion or variable states. This could include a screen-based specimen, a short kinetic typography sequence, a variable font slider, or an animation responding to rhythm, voice, sound, or route movement. This connects the project to new media alphabets and shows how the same type system can exist across print, screen, motion, and archive.

2.2 Written thesis paper

The written paper will likely include the following chapters or sections:

1. Introduction: Project context, research question, personal position, scope, significance, and the London-Sarnia corridor as the site of inquiry.
2. Typography as Archive: Type as testimony, evidence, memory, cultural record, and a way of documenting everyday Latino life.
3. Who Defines “Good Typography”? : Typographic standards, power, professionalism, design education, and decolonial critique.
4. Typographic Mechanics and Expanded Latin Character Set: Spacing, hierarchy, stroke logic, paragraph structure, accents, diacritics, extended Latin characters, and typographic testing.
5. Ethical Visibility: Consent, co-authorship, circulation, representation, anonymity, refusal, and non-extractive design.
6. Corridor Life as Visual Ecology: London-Sarnia as lived geography, including movement, labour, storefronts, domestic life, service spaces, roads, churches, schools, and visual memory.
7. Methodology: Arts-Based Research-Creation and Ways of Making: Research-creation as a method where making produces knowledge. This chapter can include interviews, visual mapping, participatory workshops, co-design, typographic sketching, type design, printmaking, documentation, and reflexive writing. This section should explain that the project is not only studying typography, but making typography as a way to think, test, listen, translate, and generate knowledge.
8. Making Process: From Co-Designed Character Set to Material Form Expanded Latin character set construction, typographic-making software, variable font testing, type specimens, poster studies, traditional printing processes, documentation, and exhibition design. Traditional printing should be framed as one of the main “ways of making,” connecting type to pressure, surface, reproduction, craft knowledge, family printing history, and material memory.
9. Analysis and Reflection: What the making reveals about typography, place, language, ethics, authorship, materiality, and your position as designer-researcher within the production of knowledge.
10. Conclusion: Contribution to design research, typography, Latino representation, arts-based research-creation,

and ethical approaches to co-designed visual systems.

2.3 Relationship between exhibition and paper

The exhibition and paper should not repeat the same information in different formats. Instead, they should do different kinds of work.

The exhibition should allow viewers to encounter the character set materially and visually. It should show the scale, texture, rhythm, colour, pressure, and spatial presence of the work. It should let viewers see the process of translation from everyday reference to letterform, from letterform to font, from font to poster, and from poster to archive.

The paper should make the argument explicit. It should explain why typography can be understood as archive, how typographic standards are shaped by power, how typographic meaning is shaped through context, how ethics enters the process, and how corridor life informs the visual system. The paper should also reflect on what the making process taught me, especially where the process complicated my original assumptions.

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Section 03: Research Questions. What are you exploring?

3.1 Main research question

How can a co-designed expanded Latin character set developed with Latino residents along the London-Sarnia corridor document everyday life, challenge dominant assumptions about typographic quality, and support ethical forms of visibility and representation?

3.2 Supporting research questions

RQ1. Typography as archive

How can typography function as archive, evidence, testimony, and cultural record rather than only as aesthetic communication?

This question asks whether an expanded Latin character set can hold more than visual style. In this thesis, the character set becomes a way to register everyday experience: migration stories, family memories, labour routes, visual habits, handwritten marks, storefront signs, religious spaces, digital messages, and objects of home. The goal is not to make a documentary in the traditional sense, but to ask how letterforms can document lived conditions through design.

This question also asks what counts as an archive. Official archives often privilege institutions, written documents, photographs, and state records. Latino everyday life in Southwestern Ontario may not always be preserved in those official spaces. Typography can help create another kind of archive, one built from lived visual culture, shared decisions, and material traces. Posters, specimens, proofs, maps, interviews, and process notes can all become part

of this archive.

Working hypothesis: A co-designed expanded Latin character set built from participants' everyday visual environments can function as documentary evidence by recording social, cultural, and spatial experiences often excluded from official archives.

Working claim: Typography can operate as testimony and archive, not only as formal communication.

RQ2. Who defines good typography?

Who has the authority to define what counts as clear, correct, readable, professional, or good typography?

This question challenges the idea that typographic quality is universal. In professional design education, good typography is often associated with balance, clarity, hierarchy, legibility, consistency, and restraint. These values are important, but they are not neutral. They come from histories of publishing, institutions, printing traditions, European modernism, design schools, commercial standards, and dominant language systems.

For Latino participants in this project, good typography may also mean recognition, accent support, cultural familiarity, warmth, improvisation, memory, sound, colour, and emotional resonance. A letterform that appears too informal in one design tradition may feel familiar or meaningful in another context. A sign that appears imperfect may still carry strong community value. This does not mean that craft or legibility should be abandoned. It means that the criteria for judging typography should be examined, expanded, and tested.

Working hypothesis: Participatory typographic workshops will show that typographic quality is culturally situated, and that participants may value recognition, belonging, language fit, and affective connection alongside professional standards.

Working claim: What counts as good typography is shaped by cultural norms, institutional histories, dominant visual and language norms, and relations of power.

RQ3. Typographic mechanics and expanded Latin character set

How do spacing, hierarchy, contrast, paragraph structure, rhythm, scale, accents, diacritics, and extended Latin characters shape the expanded Latin character set as a working typographic system?

This question grounds the project in typographic craft. It asks how the character set performs when it becomes words, lines, paragraphs, signs, posters, and digital specimens. It is not enough for the work to look conceptually strong. It must be tested as a system. Accents, diacritics, punctuation, word length, rhythm, hierarchy, and visual texture must be treated as part of the typographic system rather than as additions. Spacing, paragraph structure, and typographic texture need to be tested through the language practices that appear in the research.

Working hypothesis: Systematic typographic testing will show how spacing, rhythm, hierarchy, accents, diacritics, and material conditions shape the cultural and formal presence of the expanded Latin character set.

Working claim: Microtypographic decisions are not only technical adjustments. They are cultural choices that shape how a type system carries memory, recognition, and place.

RQ4. Ethical visibility

How can the project support visibility without becoming extractive, reductive, or disconnected from participant agency?

Visibility is not automatically ethical. Making a community more visible can support recognition, but it can also expose participants to misrepresentation, simplification, surveillance, or cultural branding. This is especially important when personal stories, language, migration histories, and cultural references are translated into public design works.

This question asks how consent, anonymity, authorship, review, circulation, and refusal will be handled. Participants should not be treated as sources of visual material to be mined. They should have meaningful control over what is collected, what is interpreted, what becomes public, and how their contributions are named or protected. The project must ask who benefits from the work and how the final character set avoids turning lived experience into decorative style.

Working hypothesis: When participants retain control over selection, naming, interpretation, and circulation, typographic representation can support visibility in ways that are more ethical, collaborative, and resistant to extraction.

Working claim: Ethical representation requires attention to power, consent, framing, circulation, and public consequence.

RQ5. Corridor life as visual ecology

How does the London-Sarnia corridor shape the visual references, stories, and letterforms of the project?

This question grounds the thesis in place. The corridor is not only a background. It is a lived environment made of routes, infrastructures, industries, fields, stores, kitchens, community spaces, churches, sidewalks, highways, bus rides, workplaces, and digital networks. These environments shape what participants see, remember, trust, avoid, and carry with them.

A visual ecology approach means studying how signs, surfaces, materials, movements, and bodies interact. It also means recognizing that Latino life in Southwestern Ontario is not located in a single neighbourhood or one symbolic place. It may be dispersed across commutes, work shifts, family networks, community events, restaurants, student life, religious spaces, and online communication.

Working hypothesis: The visual environments of the London-Sarnia corridor will reveal recurring typographic patterns connected to labour, transit, commerce, domestic life, and community identity, and those patterns will shape the character set.

Working claim: Typography is shaped by place. It emerges not only from formal design history, but also from the everyday environments through which people move, work, and build meaning.

RQ6. Traditional printing processes

How can traditional printing processes function as methods of expression, material inquiry, and knowledge production within the development of a co-designed expanded Latin character set?

This question examines how traditional printing processes can move the character set beyond digital type design and into material form. Through printmaking, the letterforms are tested through surface, impression, repetition, texture, registration, editioning, and public display. The process is not treated only as production, but as a way of thinking

Working hypothesis: Traditional printing processes will reveal aspects of the co-designed expanded Latin character set that may not appear through digital type design alone. By translating the type into printed form, the project will show how material conditions such as surface, impression, texture, scale, and repetition shape the meaning, presence, and cultural force of the letterforms.

3.3 Research question diagram

4.1 Objective 1: Develop a co-designed expanded Latin character set through arts-based research-creation

The first objective is to develop an expanded Latin character set or type family through a research-creation process involving Latino participants along the London-Sarnia corridor. This character set should emerge from interviews,

visual mapping, observation, typographic analysis, sketching, digital drawing, and iterative testing. It should not simply illustrate Latino identity. It should be built from specific references, conversations, sites, and design decisions.

This objective connects to interdisciplinary practice because the expanded Latin character set will be both a design outcome and a research method. It will require type design, qualitative research, visual culture analysis, participatory practice, and reflective writing. The final character set will be judged not only by its formal quality, but also by how responsibly it carries the process, relationships, and decisions that shaped it.

4.2 Objective 2: Examine who defines typographic quality

The second objective is to question the authority of inherited typographic standards. The project will examine how ideas such as legibility, readability, professionalism, neutrality, consistency, and correctness are produced. It will ask how those standards relate to institutions, language dominance, design education, publishing conventions, and Euro-American typographic histories.

This objective does not reject craft. Instead, it asks how craft can be made more accountable. The character set will still need careful spacing, rhythm, hierarchy, and glyph construction. However, the project will also ask whether participants recognize themselves in the form, whether accented characters are respected, whether the language practices in the work feel respected, and whether the visual system can carry emotional and cultural meaning.

4.3 Objective 3: Test typographic mechanics within an expanded Latin character set

The third objective is to test the expanded Latin character set as a working typographic system. This includes spacing, rhythm, hierarchy, scale, weight, accents, punctuation, numerals, diacritics, and selected extended Latin glyphs.

The project will produce proofs, specimens, posters, and screen-based tests to evaluate how the character set performs across different formats. Typographic-making software and digital proofing tools will support the development, testing, and refinement of the font.

This objective focuses on how individual glyphs work together as a system. It will test whether the character set is consistent, flexible, culturally recognizable, and formally connected to the visual references gathered through the research.

4.4 Objective 4: Use traditional printing and letterpress processes as material research

The fourth objective is to produce a poster series using traditional printing and letterpress processes as material research. This process will test how the expanded Latin character set changes when it moves from digital type design into printed form.

The poster process will examine edge quality, texture, impression, contrast, paper response, registration, editioning, and scale. It will also test how the printed surface changes the way viewers experience the character set.

This objective treats printing as research, not only as production. Traditional printing and letterpress processes place a contemporary co-designed character set inside historical methods of reproduction. They also connect the project to labour, craft knowledge, ancestry, touch, material memory, and the movement of typography across digital, printed, motion, exhibition, and archival formats.

The poster process will examine:

- How digital outlines become physical printing surfaces.
- How relief printing changes edge quality, texture, pressure, and contrast.
- How paper choice affects ink absorption, impression, and typographic clarity.
- How registration and editioning produce variation inside repetition.
- How the character set performs at poster scale.
- How the printed work changes the viewer's relation to the character set.
- How older print technology can dialogue with new media typography.

4.5 Objective 5: Explore the relationship between material and narrative

The fifth objective is to study how materials carry narrative. Ink, paper, plate, pressure, registration, screen, vector file, font data, route map, and wall installation all shape how the story is told. A letterform produced through traditional printing communicates differently from the same letterform displayed on a screen. The material is not neutral. It affects how the character set feels, how it circulates, and how viewers understand it.

For example, a deeply impressed letterpress poster may suggest weight, memory, presence, and touch. A variable digital specimen may suggest movement, adaptability, and systems. A map may suggest route, distance, and connection. A paragraph proof may suggest everyday reading. The thesis will examine how each material condition changes the meaning of the character set.

4.6 Objective 6: Build an ethical and reflexive design process

The sixth objective is to create a process that is ethically accountable. This includes informed consent, participant review, careful naming, anonymization where needed, shared decision-making, and attention to circulation. The project must clearly define what participants are agreeing to, what will be public, what can remain private, and how their contributions will be represented.

Reflexive writing will be used throughout the process to examine my own role. This writing will ask:

- Why did I choose this reference?
- What am I translating into typography?
- What might be lost in that translation?
- Who has the authority to approve the form?
- What does the participant recognize in the outcome?
- What does the material process add or distort?
- What should remain unprinted, unnamed, or private?

4.7 Objective 7: Produce a thesis exhibition and paper that communicate the research clearly

The final objective is to produce a coherent thesis exhibition and written paper. The exhibition should be visually strong, materially rich, and conceptually clear. The paper should articulate the project's contribution to typography, design research, Latino representation, and research-creation.

Section 05: Theoretical and critical backgrounds

The theoretical background of this thesis is organized through six areas that correspond to the project's research questions.

5.1 Typography as archive, testimony, and discourse

The first theoretical area positions typography as a form of discourse, not simply a container for language. Typography participates in meaning. It affects tone, authority, pace, memory, hierarchy, and public presence. A typeface can make a message feel official, intimate, vernacular, urgent, nostalgic, commercial, sacred, or experimental. Rob Waller's chapter "Typography and Discourse," in *Handbook of Reading Research, Volume II*, is useful because it supports the idea that typography is part of communication and interpretation, not an invisible background (Waller, 1991, pp. 341–380). Sofie Beier's "Letterform Research: An Academic Orphan" helps position type design as a legitimate research field, especially because she argues that letterform research needs stronger links between reading research, design knowledge, and testing (Beier, 2016, pp. 64–79). Herbert Spencer's *Pioneers of Modern Typography* also provides historical grounding for treating letterforms as sites of experimentation, especially through modernist, avant-garde, and experimental approaches to graphic form (Spencer, 2004).

Walter Benjamin's "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility: Second Version" is important for thinking about character sets, posters, type specimens, and fonts as reproducible cultural forms (Benjamin, 2008, pp. 19–55). Letterpress posters, type specimens, and fonts are made to circulate. Reproduction does not simply duplicate an original. It changes authority, access, and context. This is especially important for the traditional printing and letterpress process, where each print belongs to an edition but may also carry slight material variation. The poster is both repeatable and singular.

Raphaël Ouellet's "From Forms to Form: Contemporary Art and the Practice of Bureaucratic Everyday Life" supports the use of ordinary graphic traces as cultural material (Ouellet, 2024, pp. 116–127). Forms, signs, receipts, notices, menus, WhatsApp screenshots, handwritten lists, and storefront graphics can all become meaningful because they organize everyday life. They may not appear important in official archives, but they carry evidence of how people live, work, and communicate.

The project also connects to protest typography and public voice. *Strikethrough: Typographic Messages of Protest* is useful because it frames lettering, type, posters, and printed ephemera as tools for resistance, visibility, and collective memory (Munro, 2022). *Protest Cultures: A Companion* can support this section through chapters such as "Posters and Placards" and "Typography and Text Design," which connect protest to graphic form, public messaging, and the visual organization of dissent (Demarmels, 2016, pp. 233–242; Spitzmüller, 2016, pp. 259–263).

Even if this thesis is not only about protest, it is concerned with visibility, representation, and the politics of public messages. Posters are historically connected to calls, announcements, demands, celebrations, and public gathering. The printed typographic posters can therefore be understood as public works that claim presence.

5.2 Typographic quality, power, and normativity

The second theoretical area questions who defines “good typography.” Richard A. Lynch’s chapter “Foucault’s Theory of Power,” in *Michel Foucault: Key Concepts*, is useful because it explains power as something that does not only prohibit, but also produces norms, categories, knowledge, and accepted truths (Lynch, 2010, pp. 13–26). In typography, standards of correctness and professionalism can appear natural, but they are shaped through institutions, publications, design education, software defaults, design histories, and professional gatekeeping.

Gurminder K. Bhambra’s article “Decolonizing Critical Theory? Epistemological Justice, Progress, Reparations” helps question whose histories, methods, and standards become treated as universal (Bhambra, 2021, pp. 73–89). This supports the thesis by asking how typographic knowledge has been shaped by Eurocentric design histories, and how other visual practices can challenge inherited ideas of clarity, refinement, and legitimacy.

Homi K. Bhabha’s *The Location of Culture* can support the discussion of hybridity, ambivalence, and cultural authority. The most relevant chapters are “Of Mimicry and Man: The Ambivalence of Colonial Discourse,” which begins on page 121, and “Signs Taken for Wonders: Questions of Ambivalence and Authority Under a Tree Outside Delhi, May 1817,” which begins on page 145 in the Routledge Classics edition (Bhabha, 2004). These chapters are useful for thinking about diasporic and hybrid forms that resist purity, fixed identity, or a single visual standard.

Vicki Kirby’s *Judith Butler: Live Theory* can be used as a supporting source for thinking about norm-making, performativity, and how certain forms become recognized as proper or improper. The most relevant chapters are “Gender, Sexuality, Performance: Gender Trouble,” “Gender, Sexuality, Performance: Bodies that Matter,” and “Language, Power, Performativity: Excitable Speech” (Kirby, 2006). This source is not specifically about typography, but it can help frame how visual forms may be judged as excessive, strange, improper, or illegible when they disturb dominant norms.

Sofia Vranou’s article “Performing the Subcultural Freak: Leigh Bowery’s Peculiar Narcissism and the Disruption of Normativity” can also support this discussion (Vranou, 2020, pp. 326–339). Vranou is useful for thinking about how visual excess, transgression, and nonconformity can challenge dominant ideas of taste, body, style, and acceptability. In this thesis, that idea can be translated carefully into typography by asking why some letterforms are accepted as refined, while others are dismissed as too vernacular, too decorative, or too informal.

Within typography itself, Gerrit Noordzij and Jost Hochuli are important but different kinds of sources. Noordzij’s *The Stroke: Theory of Writing* helps explain that letterforms are built through tools, movement, contrast, direction, white space, and writing traditions (Noordzij, 2005/2019). This supports the thesis because it shows that typography is historically tied to the body, the hand, and inherited training. Hochuli’s *Detail in Typography* represents a precise professional tradition focused on letters, letterspacing, words, wordspacing, lines, linespacing, columns, and legibility (Hochuli, 2008/2015). Rather than rejecting Hochuli, the thesis can use him as a standard to examine and test. The question becomes: what happens when professional standards of typographic detail meet community-informed forms of reading, memory, and visual culture?

Frank Chimero’s *The Shape of Design* can support the discussion of design judgment, process, and value. The most relevant chapters are “How and Why,” “Craft and Beauty,” “Improvisation and Limitations,” and “Context and

Response” (Chimero, 2012). Chimero helps argue that design quality is not only technical. It is connected to intention, context, audience, response, and meaning. This supports the thesis by framing “good typography” as something that must be tested through both craft and situated use.

5.3 Typographic mechanics, perception, and situated reading

The third theoretical area focuses on reading as embodied, spatial, and situated. Typography is not only seen. It is experienced through habits of perception, body orientation, language familiarity, visual rhythm, and environment. This is important because the expanded Latin character set will be tested not only as a formal system, but as something encountered through bodies, places, materials, and everyday situations.

Gloria Anzaldúa’s *Borderlands/La Frontera: The New Mestiza* is central to this section, especially Chapter 5, “How to Tame a Wild Tongue.” This chapter connects language, border identity, hybridity, and lived contradiction. It helps frame language variation as a site of knowledge, memory, and identity rather than as something to be corrected. Chapter 7, “La conciencia de la mestiza,” can also support the project’s discussion of hybridity and cultural negotiation. Page numbers vary by edition, but “How to Tame a Wild Tongue” is commonly listed around pp. 53–64 in Aunt Lute editions.

Sara Ahmed’s *Queer Phenomenology: Orientations, Objects, Others* supports the idea that orientation matters. Ahmed’s Introduction and Chapter 1, “Orientations Toward Objects,” are the most useful for this project because they explain how bodies are situated in space and how some bodies, objects, and directions are made easier to reach than others. This helps the thesis ask how typography can make some readers feel oriented, while others may need to adjust, translate, or navigate differently. Duke University Press describes the book as focusing on how bodies are situated in space and time, and how orientation affects what is proximate or reachable.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty’s *Phenomenology of Perception* supports the idea that perception is embodied and situated. The most relevant sections are Part One, “The Body,” especially “The Body as Object and Mechanistic Physiology,” “The Spatiality of One’s Own Body and Motility,” and “The Body as Expression and Speech.” In the 2002 Psychology Press edition, these sections begin on pp. 84, 112, and 202. These chapters can help connect reading to the body, gesture, movement, and lived perception rather than treating reading as an abstract visual act.

James J. Gibson’s *The Ecological Approach to Visual Perception* adds that seeing is shaped by surfaces, movement, environment, and action. Chapter 2, “Medium, Substances, Surfaces,” and Chapter 8, “The Theory of Affordances,” are especially relevant. Gibson’s theory of affordances helps explain how environments offer possibilities for action and perception. For this thesis, this supports the idea that signs, storefronts, roads, posters, domestic objects, and printed surfaces are not passive backgrounds. They shape how people notice, move, remember, and read. These ideas are important for typography because reading is not abstract. It happens in bodies, places, and contexts. A reader encounters signs while driving, shopping, commuting, praying, texting, cooking, working, or navigating an institution. Type is read under different distances, lighting conditions, emotional states, materials, and levels of familiarity. This means the project must test the expanded Latin character set through real uses, not only through neutral specimens.

Hochuli and Cyrus Highsmith are useful technical anchors. Jost Hochuli’s *Detail in Typography* supports the study of micro-typographic decisions such as letters, letterspacing, words, wordspacing, lines, linespacing, columns, punctuation, and legibility. The book is short, around 64 pages, and can be used throughout the mechanics and testing sections. Cyrus Highsmith’s *Inside Paragraphs: Typographic Fundamentals* is especially useful for analyzing what happens when letters become words, words become lines, and lines become paragraphs. The publisher

describes the book as focused on printed text inside the paragraph and the role of white space between letters, words, and lines.

Together, these sources allow the thesis to connect critical theory to practical typographic testing. Anzaldúa and Ahmed help frame language, orientation, and power. Merleau-Ponty and Gibson help frame embodied and ecological perception. Hochuli and Highsmith provide the technical language for testing spacing, rhythm, hierarchy, paragraph structure, and typographic texture within the expanded Latin character set.

5.4 Ethical visibility, care, and non-extractive representation

The fourth theoretical area addresses ethics, especially the problem of visibility. In this thesis, visibility is not automatically positive. A poster, font, map, or exhibition can celebrate community presence, but it can also expose, simplify, aestheticize, or misrepresent people's lives. For that reason, the project must treat consent, participant review, anonymity, refusal, and circulation as part of the design method, not as secondary concerns.

Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble: Making Kin in the Chthulucene* is useful because it argues for situated, relational, and accountable forms of thinking. The most relevant sections are the Introduction, Chapter 1, "Playing String Figures with Companion Species," Chapter 3, "Sympoiesis," Chapter 5, "Awash in Urine: DES and Premarin in Multispecies Response-ability," and Chapter 7, "A Curious Practice" (Haraway, 2016, pp. 1–8, 9–29, 58–98, 104–116, 126–133). These chapters help frame design as a process of relation rather than detached authorship. Haraway is especially useful for thinking about how the designer is implicated in the research situation, because accountability is produced through relationships, materials, histories, and decisions.

Rose-Redwood, Barnd, Lucchesi, Dias, and Patrick's "Decolonizing the Map: Recentering Indigenous Mappings" is useful for the corridor mapping section because it argues that mapping must move beyond colonial cartographic frames by centering Indigenous geographical knowledge, protocols, and participation (Rose-Redwood et al., 2020, pp. 151–162). This matters for the thesis because mapping, naming, routes, and spatial representation are never neutral. When the project documents corridor life and turns places, roads, or storefronts into visual material, it must ask who controls the meaning of those places and how they are represented.

Tyna Fritschy's "Queer Indiscipline, Decolonial Revolt: The Production of Undisciplined Knowledges in the Neoliberal Age" can support the project's resistance to over-classification and institutional flattening (Fritschy, 2021, pp. 127–139). This source is useful because the thesis does not only organize community experience into a clean archive. It also needs to leave space for uncertainty, contradiction, affect, memory, and forms of knowledge that do not fit neatly into academic or design categories.

Nora S. Vaage's "What Ethics for Bioart?" is useful as a supporting source on ethics in experimental art practice (Vaage, 2016, pp. 87–104). Although Vaage writes specifically about bioart, the source helps this thesis because it shows that experimentation does not remove responsibility. Artistic research still needs ethical attention when it uses people, materials, technologies, or living contexts as part of the work. Vaage's broader research also connects art, new technologies, ethics, and knowledge production within artistic research.

Sasha Luccioni's work can be used if digital tools, AI, or computational processes enter the workflow. "Stable Bias: Evaluating Societal Representations in Diffusion Models" is relevant because it examines how image-generation systems can reproduce or intensify social bias and under-represent marginalized identities (Luccioni et al., 2023). "Misinformation by Omission: The Need for More Environmental Transparency in AI" is also useful because it argues that AI systems often lack transparency about costs, impacts, and resource demands (Luccioni et al., 2025). These

sources can help the thesis address simplification, bias, extraction, and opacity if computational tools are used in the design process.

The central ethical issue is that visibility can be double-edged. Public presentation can create recognition and presence, but it can also expose people to misreading, stereotyping, or unwanted attention. Ethical visibility is therefore not only about showing. It is about asking who controls the terms of showing, who can refuse, who reviews the work, and how the final character set, posters, maps, and exhibition circulate.

5.5 Corridor life, diaspora, hybridity, and visual ecology

The fifth theoretical area concerns place. The London-Sarnia corridor is a lived geography shaped by movement, labour, migration, industry, agriculture, highways, domestic spaces, stores, religious life, education, and community networks. The thesis should not generalize Latino life as if it exists outside place. It must ask what is specific about this region and how place shapes the visual material used to build the expanded Latin character set.

This regional focus is supported by local demographic change. In London, immigrants represented 24.8% of the city's population in 2021, increasing from 22.2% in 2016 and 21.2% in 2011. In the wider London-Middlesex region, a 2025 newcomer survey reports that more than 100,000 people, approximately 25% of the population, were foreign-born immigrants in 2021, and 19.1% of immigrants had arrived between 2016 and 2021.

Latino presence is also visible in the census data, although Statistics Canada records this through the category "Latin American" within the visible minority/racialized population variable. In London, the Latin American population increased from 9,045 in 2016 to 12,580 in 2021, a growth of approximately 39%. In Sarnia, the Latin American population increased from 390 in 2016 to 620 in 2021, a growth of approximately 59%. These numbers do not capture the full complexity of Latino identity, language, migration history, or cultural belonging, but they help show that Latino presence in the corridor is measurable, growing, and regionally specific.

At the same time, the corridor is not uniform. London functions as a larger urban and institutional centre, while Sarnia and Lambton County are shaped by different relationships to industry, smaller-city life, border proximity, mobility, and regional labour. The Sarnia census agglomeration counted 10,080 immigrants in 2021, representing 10.5% of its population. These differences matter because the thesis is not only about Latino identity in general. It is about how Latino life is experienced across a specific Southwestern Ontario geography.

Kalra, Kaur, and Hutnyk's *Diaspora & Hybridity* is useful because it treats diaspora and hybridity as political and contested, not simply celebratory. Chapter 4, "Hybrid Connections," and Chapter 5, "Hybridity and Openness (or, Whose Side Are You On?)," are the most relevant sections for this thesis. These chapters help frame cultural mixing as something shaped by power, migration, race, belonging, and political struggle rather than as a neutral blend of styles. This is important because the thesis should not turn Latino visual culture into a decorative idea of hybridity. It should ask how hybrid forms emerge from specific histories, routes, labour conditions, and social relations.

Zakiya Luna's article "'Truly a Women of Color Organization': Negotiating Sameness and Difference in Pursuit of Intersectionality" can support the project's thinking about location, difference, and collective identity. Luna examines how organizations negotiate sameness and difference when building collective identity across race, class, and other social positions. For this thesis, Luna is useful because Latino identity should not be treated as one shared experience. The project must remain attentive to differences among participants, including migration history, language, class, work, age, gender, and connection to place.

Giuliana Bruno's *Surface: Matters of Aesthetics, Materiality, and Media* helps frame place through surfaces, architecture, projection, walls, screens, façades, and material memory. The most useful sections are "Surfaces of Light," especially Chapter 3, "Light Spaces, Screen Surfaces: On the Fabric of Projection," Chapter 4, "The Surface Tension of Media: Texture, Canvas, Screen," and Chapter 8, "Projections: The Architectural Imaginary in Art." Bruno is useful for understanding storefronts, walls, interiors, signs, screens, and exhibition surfaces as visual sites where memory and mediation happen. This connects directly to the corridor because the project studies everyday visual surfaces as sources for typographic form.

Celiane Camargo-Borges's "Creativity and Imagination: Research as World Making!" is useful for the methodology of place-based research-creation. The chapter appears in *Handbook of Arts-Based Research* and is listed as pp. 88–100 in the version I found. Camargo-Borges argues for research as a creative, social, and generative practice rather than a neutral process of discovery. This supports the thesis because the corridor is not only being documented. It is being interpreted, remade, and made meaningful through conversations, mapping, type design, printing, and exhibition.

Watfern, Watson, Doran, and Vaughan's "A Sad Tree: Visualising Ecological Emotions Through Bodies in Place" can support the affective dimension of place. The article appears in *Visual Studies*, 40(2), pp. 361–370. It uses body mapping, drawing, collage, and found local materials to explore emotions connected to place and ecological experience. For this thesis, the source is useful because corridor life is not only visual or geographic. It is also felt through memory, movement, attachment, labour, displacement, and everyday routine.

Together, these sources help frame the London-Sarnia corridor as an environment that is seen, felt, remembered, and remade through design. Place is not only a background for the project. It is part of the knowledge produced by the thesis. The expanded Latin character set, posters, specimens, maps, and exhibition materials should therefore respond to the corridor as a lived visual ecology rather than as a generic location.

5.6 Traditional Printing Methods and Letterpress Work

Traditional printing methods are a key part of this thesis because they allow the expanded Latin character set to move from digital design into physical form. The project does not treat printing only as a final production stage. Instead, letterpress and related traditional printing processes become methods of material research. They help test how type behaves through surface, impression, scale, texture, repetition, and public display.

Caroline Archer-Parré and James Mussell's edited volume *Letterpress Printing: Past, Present, Future* is useful because it frames letterpress as both historical technology and contemporary practice. In their introduction, they explain that letterpress was the dominant mode of textual reproduction in the West for more than 500 years, but that its current revival is not simply nostalgic. It is also a way of preserving craft knowledge, experimenting with new technologies, and asking new questions about print in the digital age (Archer-Parré & Mussell, 2023, Introduction). This supports the thesis because the poster series uses traditional printing not to look backward, but to test how a contemporary co-designed type system changes through material production.

D. F. McKenzie's *Bibliography and the Sociology of Texts* is also central here. McKenzie argues that the physical form of a text affects its meaning, and that bibliography should study not only books, but also visual, oral, numeric, graphic, and material forms of communication. The most relevant section is "Bibliography and the Sociology of Texts" (pp. 7–76), especially the discussion that "forms effect meaning" around p. 13 (McKenzie, 1999). This helps frame the printed poster as more than a surface that carries the character set. The poster's paper, impression, scale, editioning, and production process become part of what the type means.

Johanna Drucker is useful for connecting print, materiality, and artists' books. Her *The Century of Artists' Books* studies artists' books through structure, form, sequence, and conceptualization, which can support the way this thesis treats posters, specimens, and process documentation as research objects rather than only presentation formats (Drucker, 1995/2004). Her chapter "Letterpress Aesthetics" in *Letterpress Printing: Past, Present, Future* is especially relevant for thinking about letterpress as a visual and material language, not only a technical process.

Dori Griffin's *Type Specimens: A Visual History of Typesetting and Printing* can support the specimen and poster components of the thesis. Griffin studies type specimens, broadsides, printers' manuals, posters, and ephemera as objects that show how letterforms, printing technologies, and typographic practice develop over time. This is useful because the thesis will produce specimens and posters not only to show the expanded Latin character set, but also to test spacing, weight, rhythm, accents, punctuation, and material behaviour (Griffin, 2021/2022).

Walter Benjamin's "The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technological Reproducibility" can support the discussion of reproduction, circulation, and editioning. His essay is useful for thinking about how printed works change meaning when they are reproduced and circulated publicly. In this thesis, the poster is repeatable because it belongs to an edition, but it is also singular because each print can carry small differences of pressure, surface, texture, and registration (Benjamin, 2008, pp. 19–55).

This section also connects to my personal history. My family has owned and worked with print shops for more than three generations, so traditional printing is not only a technical method in this thesis. It is connected to labour, craft knowledge, ancestry, touch, and memory. The press, plate, paper, proof, and printed surface become part of how I understand typography as something made through hands, tools, repetition, correction, and care.

The poster series will use the expanded Latin character set to test how printed type can carry memory, place, and cultural presence. These posters may include character set specimens, type weight tests, participant-informed words, corridor references, illustrative posters of participants, and process documentation. Each printed work will help evaluate how the character set performs outside the screen and how it changes when it enters a public, physical, and reproducible format.

Traditional printing therefore becomes a way of thinking through ancestry, labour, touch, and memory. It connects contemporary type design with older forms of making, while allowing the thesis to ask how a co-designed expanded Latin character set can become both a working typographic system and a material record of lived experience.

Section 06: Research methodology. What and why choosing this strategy?

The methodology is research-creation, supported by qualitative methods, participatory design, visual mapping, typographic testing, printmaking, and reflexive writing. This strategy is appropriate because the thesis does not only ask a question through writing. It investigates through making.

6.1 Research-creation

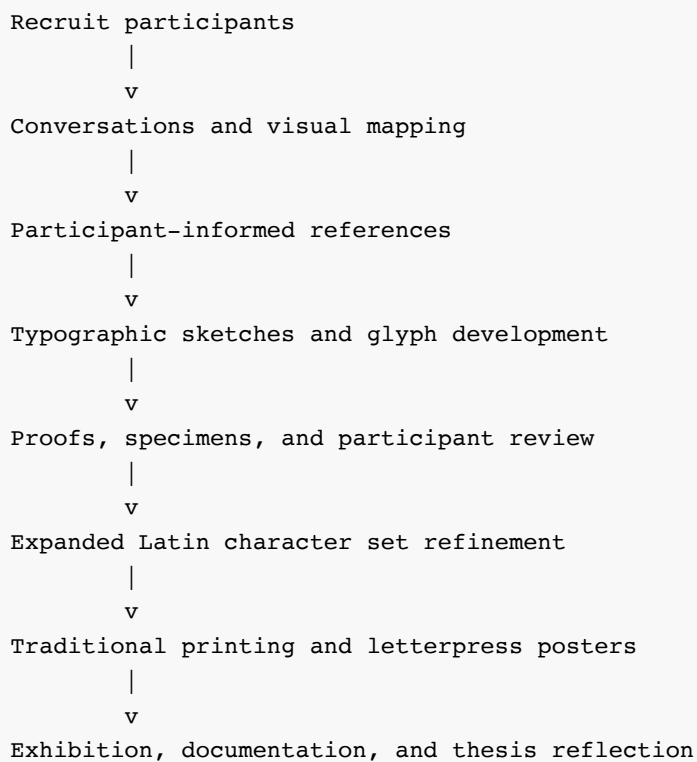
Research-creation is the main methodological frame because the project produces knowledge through creative practice. The character set, posters, specimens, proofs, maps, and exhibition are not illustrations of research that

already happened elsewhere. They are part of the research itself. Decisions about spacing, pressure, materials, glyph design, participant input, and exhibition layout will generate knowledge.

This strategy is necessary because typography is a practice-based field. Questions about rhythm, texture, pressure, scale, visual recognition, and typographic clarity cannot be answered only through theoretical writing. They must be tested through drawing, printing, reading, looking, comparing, revising, and displaying.

In this thesis, co-design does not mean that participants are responsible for technical font production. Instead, it means that participants help shape the references, meanings, criteria, review process, and decisions that guide the expanded Latin character set. Participants may take part in one or more activities: a semi-structured conversation, a visual mapping exercise, a review of typographic sketches, and a response session with printed or digital proofs.

The working sequence will move through the following stages:



6.2 Semi-structured interviews

Semi-structured interviews will allow participants to discuss their experiences of language, place, memory, and visual culture. The interviews should not be treated as extraction. They should be conversations that help identify meaningful references, words, objects, routes, places, and visual memories.

Possible interview themes include:

- Migration, settlement, and belonging.
- Everyday movement along the corridor.
- Places that feel important, familiar, or difficult.
- Language practices used at home, work, school, online, and in public.

- Signs, storefronts, handwritten notes, packaging, devotional objects, textiles, music, or digital messages that participants remember.
- Feelings about visibility, representation, privacy, and public display.
- What makes typography feel familiar, formal, trustworthy, cold, warm, official, beautiful, or alienating.

Semi-structured interviews are appropriate because they offer enough structure to connect responses to the research questions, while leaving room for unexpected stories and references.

6.3 Visual mapping and participant reference gathering

Visual mapping will help connect memory, place, and form. Participants may be invited to map routes, places, signs, words, colours, textures, or objects that matter to them. They may also bring or describe visual references. This method is useful because it allows the character set to emerge from situated visual worlds rather than from my assumptions alone.

Possible mapping activities include:

- Route map: a map of regular movement through London, Sarnia, and surrounding areas.
- Memory map: places connected to family, work, food, worship, study, care, or community.
- Sign map: signs, storefronts, handwritten notes, labels, menus, or digital interfaces participants remember.
- Language map: where participant expressions, accents, signs, and visual language practices appear.
- Feeling map: where participants feel visible, invisible, welcome, watched, comfortable, or displaced.

The maps do not need to be cartographically precise. Their value is in showing relationships between place, memory, and visual reference.

6.4 Participatory typographic workshops

Workshops will allow participants to respond to letterforms, compare visual directions, discuss typographic clarity, cultural recognition, and contribute to the criteria of quality. These workshops may include printed proofs, digital previews, word tests, character set sheets, and simple ranking or annotation activities.

Participants might be asked:

- Which forms feel familiar or unfamiliar?
- Which letters feel connected to the references we discussed?
- Which letters feel forced or decorative?
- Which words or phrases work at different sizes?
- Which accents or characters need more care?
- What would you change before this becomes public?
- What should not be included?

The workshops are important because they shift participants from being sources to being evaluators and co-authors. They help answer the question of who defines good typography.

6.5 Type design and typographic mechanics testing

The character set will be developed through type design workflows. This includes sketching, digitizing, drawing outlines, spacing, kerning, testing accents, generating proofs, and possibly building variable font axes.

The testing process may include:

- Glyph construction sheets.
- Control words.
- Accented character tests.
- Participant-informed word lists.
- Paragraph proofs.
- Poster-scale proofs.
- Weight, contrast, and spacing variations.
- Print versus screen comparisons.
- Participant feedback on clarity, recognition, and typographic presence.

This method is necessary because the project makes claims about typographic quality, cultural recognition, and material performance. Those claims must be tested through typographic mechanics.

6.6 Traditional printing and letterpress poster methodology

Traditional printing and letterpress poster production will be treated as a supervised printmaking research method. The aim is not to provide a machine operation manual. The process should only be developed with proper training, facility approval, and expert supervision. In the thesis, the important point is the research value of the process: how the expanded Latin character set changes when it enters physical printing.

6.6.1 Why traditional printing and letterpress matter to the thesis

Traditional printing and letterpress processes are significant because they bring together typography, reproduction, mechanical rhythm, pressure, labour, and editioning. These processes are often associated with commercial print production, but in this thesis they become research tools. They allow the expanded Latin character set to become a physical impression, not only a digital outline.

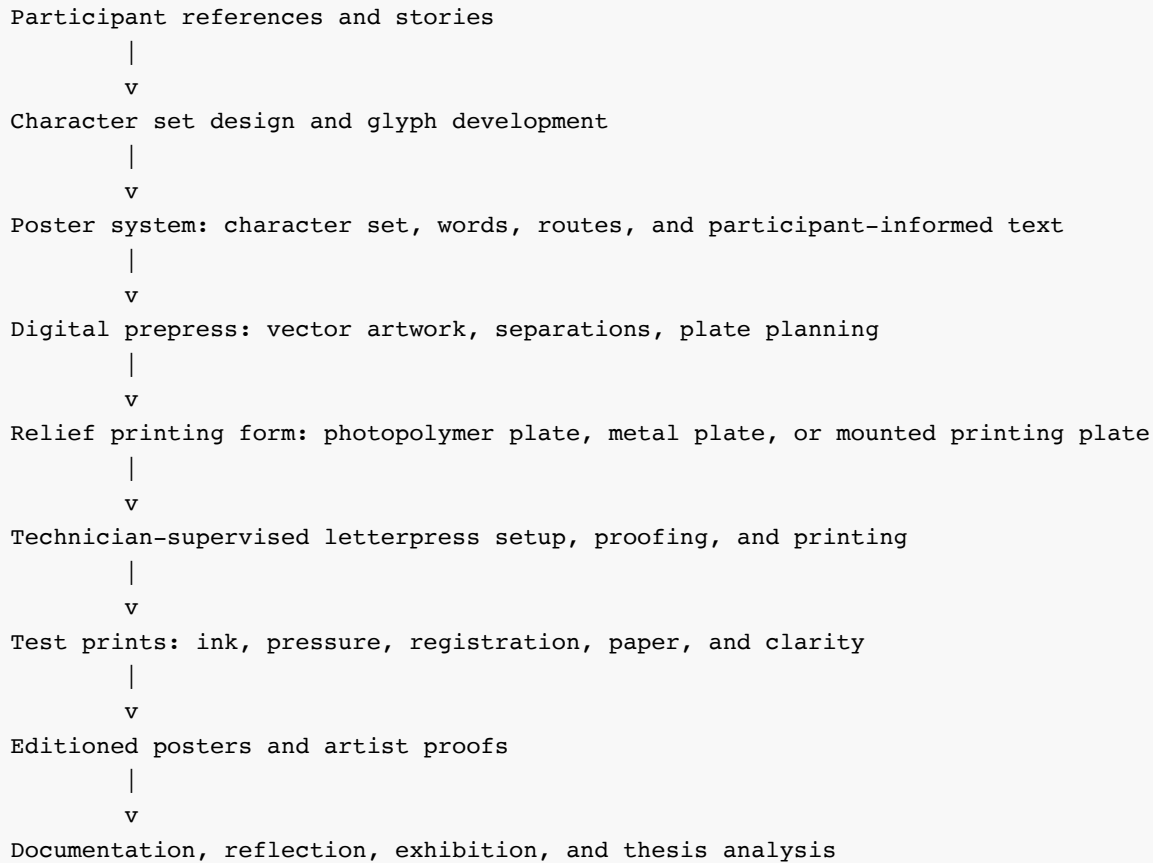
Traditional printing and letterpress are especially relevant for four reasons:

1. Reproducibility: The character set can be printed in multiples, creating a public edition.
2. Materiality: The printed surface creates a tactile record through paper, ink, pressure, texture, and impression.
3. Translation: The type moves from digital design into physical printing, revealing changes in edge quality, density, rhythm, and scale.
4. Archive: Each proof, test, correction, and final print becomes part of the project's process archive.

This process matters because the thesis studies typography as both a working system and a material form of knowledge. Traditional printing allows the project to test how letterforms behave when they enter a physical process of pressure, repetition, and public display. It also connects the thesis to ancestry, labour, touch, memory, and my family's history with print shops across more than three generations.

6.6.2 Poster production stages

The poster process will be organized as a research workflow:



6.6.3 Stage 1: Selecting poster content

The poster content will come from the research process. Possible content includes:

- The full co-designed expanded Latin character set.
- Participant-informed words or phrases, only with consent.
- Place names from the corridor.
- Participants' ways of living, seeing, remembering, and moving through place.
- Signs, routes, or object references translated into typographic composition.
- Short statements about language, home, movement, or belonging.

The content must be reviewed ethically. If a phrase comes from a participant, the participant should approve whether it can be printed, anonymized, translated, or excluded.

6.6.4 Stage 2: Designing the poster system

The poster system should test the expanded Latin character set in multiple ways. It should include display settings, text settings, large glyphs, small supporting text, accents, numerals, punctuation, and participant-informed hierarchy. The posters should not only be beautiful. They should also test the typeface.

Design questions include:

- What happens when the character set is printed very large?
- Which details survive letterpress pressure?
- Do diacritics remain visible?
- Does the rhythm of the character set feel connected to the original references?
- Can the poster hold both archive and public presence?
- Does the poster feel like a specimen, a memory object, a public announcement, or all three?

6.6.5 Stage 3: Translating digital type into a relief printing form

The digital type must be prepared for relief printing. This may involve converting selected typography into vector outlines and producing a plate or other relief printing form. In letterpress contexts, the word often used for “cliché” is **printing plate**, **relief plate**, **photopolymer plate**, **metal plate**, or **printing block**, depending on the production method.

This translation is conceptually important. A digital outline is clean, scalable, and editable. A relief plate fixes the form into a physical surface. Once the character set becomes a plate, it enters another logic: depth, ink transfer, pressure, and repetition. The thesis can analyze what is gained and what is lost in that translation.

6.6.6 Stage 4: Paper, ink, and material tests

Paper and ink will be selected as part of the research. Cotton rag paper, archival printmaking paper, or other substantial stocks may be tested for their ability to hold impression and ink. Different papers will change the character set’s edge quality, density, and tactile presence.

Material variables to document:

- Paper weight and texture.
- Ink colour and density.
- Impression depth.
- Edge sharpness or softness.
- Ink spread.
- Drying time.
- Registration accuracy.
- Clarity of small details and accents.
- Relationship between paper tone and typographic mood.

These tests will become part of the thesis evidence. Rejected prints are not failures only. They show how the material process thinks with the character set.

6.6.7 Stage 5: Analysis of the printed outcome

After printing, the posters will be analyzed through both formal and reflective criteria.

Formal analysis:

- Did the character set retain clarity and presence?
- Did the pressure improve or distort the form?
- How did the edge quality change?

- How did paper texture affect rhythm?
- Did the accents, punctuation, and small details survive?
- Did the poster communicate the intended hierarchy?

Reflective analysis:

- What did the press reveal that the screen did not?
- Did the printed object feel more archival, public, intimate, or institutional?
- Did the process change how I understand the character set?
- What did repetition and editioning do to the idea of testimony?
- Did the material beauty of letterpress risk aestheticizing the participant material?
- How can the exhibition show process without overexposing participant stories?

6.7 Documentation as method

Documentation will be part of the methodology, not only an afterthought. The project should document:

- Interviews and consent decisions.
- Visual references.
- Sketches and maps.
- Type design files.
- Proofs and revisions.
- Printmaking tests.
- Traditional printing and letterpress stages.
- Exhibition installation.
- Reflexive notes.

Documentation matters because the thesis argues that the process itself is archival. The archive should show how decisions were made, not only what the final output looks like.

6.8 Reflexive writing

Reflexive writing will be used throughout the project. This writing will help me identify how my own decisions shape the research. Because I am designing the character set, selecting references, composing posters, and writing the thesis, I must account for my own role.

Reflexive writing may appear as:

- Studio notes.
- Process reflections.
- Short writing beside proofs.
- Thesis chapter sections.
- Exhibition captions.
- A methodology appendix.

The goal is to avoid presenting the character set as if it naturally emerged from the community. Instead, the thesis should show the decisions, negotiations, uncertainties, and responsibilities involved.

Section 07: Resources and facilities. What will you need?

7.1 People and supervision

The project will require:

- Thesis supervisor and committee guidance.
- Ethics guidance for participant-based research.
- Latino participants along the London-Sarnia corridor.
- Printmaking technicians.
- Type design feedback from faculty, peers, or outside specialists.
- May use a possible host institution support if part of the research is conducted outside Canada.
- Conversations with makers from other material practices, such as **Gordon Boyd's glass work**, to think across craft, pressure, transparency, material resistance, and decolonizing process.

7.2 Facilities

Potential facilities include:

- OCAD University studios and critique spaces.
- Printmaking studio for proofing, paper preparation, and material tests.
- A traditional printing or letterpress facility with technician support.
- A plate-making or printing supplier for photopolymer or metal relief plates.
- A computer lab or personal workstation for type design.
- Exhibition space for installation.
- Scanning or photography facilities for documentation.
- A safe storage area for prints, proofs, plates, paper, and archive materials.

7.3 Equipment

Possible equipment includes:

- Computer with type design software.
- Glyphs, RoboFont, Fontra Pak, FontGoggles, DrawBot, Adobe Illustrator, InDesign, Photoshop, After Effects, or comparable tools.
- Camera or phone for documentation.
- Audio recorder for interviews, if approved.
- Scanner for sketches, prints, and archival references.
- Printer for proofing.
- Traditional printing or letterpress press access
- Plate base and appropriate relief printing plate.

- Drying racks.
- Cutting tools operated within studio safety rules.
- Measuring tools, proofing tools, and paper storage.

7.4 Materials

Materials may include:

- Cotton rag paper or archival printmaking paper.
- Newsprint or inexpensive proofing paper.
- Letterpress inks.
- Photopolymer plates, metal plates, or relief printing blocks.
- Plate base or mounting system appropriate to the press.
- Tracing paper, pencils, markers, tape, and notebooks.
- Archival sleeves or boxes for prints and process material.
- Exhibition wall materials, labels, frames, clips, magnets, or tables.

7.5 Digital resources

Digital resources may include:

- Font files: UFO, Glyphs files, OTF, TTF, WOFF, WOFF2, variable font files.
- Designspace files.
- Versioned proof PDFs.
- Interview transcripts or summaries, stored securely.
- Participant consent records.
- Visual reference folders.
- Photo documentation.
- Exhibition files.
- Backup storage.

7.6 Research resources

The project will require access to:

- OCAD library materials.
- Typography and design research texts.
- Research methods texts.
- Decolonial design and ethical representation readings.
- Archives or examples of protest posters, type specimens, vernacular typography, letterpress printing, and new media typography.
- Local visual research through field observation in London, Sarnia, and surrounding areas.

7.7 Resource matrix

Resource area	What is needed	Why it matters
Participants	Approximately 3 to 5 Latino residents along the corridor	Supports co-design, situated knowledge, and ethical representation
Type design software	Glyphs, RoboFont, Fontra Pak, FontGoggles	Allows drawing, spacing, interpolation, proofing, and export
Printmaking facility	Traditional printing or letterpress equipment with technician support	Enables poster production as material research
Materials	Paper, ink, plates, proofs, storage	Allows testing of texture, pressure, editioning, and archival quality
Documentation	Camera, scanner, notes, process archive	Preserves research evidence and supports thesis analysis
Exhibition space	Wall, tables, screens, frames, labels	Presents final work and process as research-creation
Ethics support	Consent forms, data storage, review process	Protects participants and supports non-extractive practice

Section 08: Potential challenges or limitations

8.1 Ethical risk and participant representation

The most important challenge is ethical representation. The project works with real people, lived experiences, cultural memory, and potentially sensitive stories. There is a risk of turning participant material into visual style, or presenting Latino life in a way that is too general, decorative, or simplified.

To address this, the project must include:

- Clear consent.
- Participant review of materials.
- Options for anonymity.
- The right to withdraw.
- The right to refuse public display of specific content.
- Careful decisions about translation.
- Avoidance of stereotypes or symbolic shortcuts.
- Reflexive writing about my own role.

8.2 Scope of the project

The project is ambitious because it includes interviews, co-design, type design, typographic testing, printmaking,

possible motion work, and exhibition. There is a risk that the project becomes too broad.

To manage scope, the project should prioritize:

1. One strong co-designed expanded Latin character set or type system.
2. One focused participant group.
3. One main poster series using traditional printing or letterpress processes.
4. A clear set of typographic tests.
5. A carefully edited exhibition rather than too many disconnected outputs.

Motion and variable font experiments should support the thesis, not distract from the core argument.

8.3 Access to traditional printing and letterpress facilities

Access to traditional printing or letterpress facilities may be limited by location, availability, cost, technician time, safety requirements, and scheduling. Since letterpress equipment is specialized, it cannot be used casually or independently without training and supervision.

Possible strategies:

- Confirm technician or printer availability early.
- Build the poster schedule around facility access dates.
- Prepare digital files and test plates before the session.
- Budget for plate production, paper, ink, studio time, and printing support.
- Use my family history and print shop connections as knowledge resources where appropriate.
- Have a backup plan using another traditional printing, letterpress, or relief printing method if the preferred facility is not available.

8.4 Technical limitations of type design

Designing a typeface is time-consuming. It requires drawing, spacing, kerning, testing, revising, and exporting. Expanded Latin character set support adds complexity because accents, diacritics, and selected extended Latin characters must be integrated carefully.

Potential limitations include:

- Incomplete glyph set.
- Spacing problems.
- Poor performance in paragraph settings.
- Accents feeling visually disconnected.
- Variable font export issues.
- Differences between screen rendering and print output.

To address this, the project should set a realistic glyph scope and prioritize characters needed for the research.

8.5 Risk of aestheticizing community experience

Letterpress posters can be visually beautiful. This beauty can be powerful, but it can also create risk. The material charm of ink, paper, and impression may make difficult experiences look polished or consumable. The project must be careful not to transform participant stories into decorative works detached from context.

Strategies include:

- Showing process and context alongside final posters.
- Including participant review.
- Avoiding overly romantic captions.
- Making clear what is co-designed, interpreted, anonymized, or speculative.
- Including reflections on what cannot or should not be represented.

8.6 Time and production constraints

Printmaking, especially editioned work, takes time. Plate production, proofing, drying, trimming, documentation, and installation must be scheduled carefully. If the posters include multiple colours, the process becomes more complex because each colour requires separate planning and registration.

A realistic production plan should include:

- Early file preparation.
- A test print stage.
- Time for revisions.
- Final production sessions.
- Drying and flattening time.
- Documentation.
- Installation planning.

8.7 Research trustworthiness

Because the project is qualitative and practice-based, the thesis must clearly explain how decisions are made. It should show how participant input leads to typographic decisions and where my own interpretation enters the work.

Strategies include:

- Keeping a decision log.
- Keeping annotated proofs.
- Documenting revisions.
- Including participant feedback summaries.
- Explaining why certain references were used or rejected.
- Using reflexive writing to acknowledge uncertainty.

Section 09: Significance of the project

9.1 Contribution to typography

This project contributes to typography by treating type design as a situated and participatory research practice. It challenges the idea that typefaces are only formal systems made for neutral communication. Instead, it shows that expanded Latin character sets can carry memory, place, visual culture, labour, and social relationships.

The project also contributes to discussions of typographic meaning and material practice. The thesis asks how letterforms gain meaning through context, cultural recognition, participant input, and material translation. Through proofs, specimens, posters, traditional printing processes, motion studies, and exhibition design, the project examines how an expanded Latin character set can function as both a working typographic system and a situated visual language.

9.2 Contribution to design and arts-based research-creation

The project contributes to arts-based research creation and design research by connecting theory and making. It brings together interviews, visual mapping, type design, traditional printing processes, and reflexive writing as interconnected methods.

Rather than treating the final works only as outcomes, the thesis understands them as research evidence. The expanded Latin character set, posters, specimens, process documentation, and exhibition materials become ways of testing ideas, recording decisions, and showing how knowledge is produced through making.

9.3 Contribution to Latino representation in Southwestern Ontario

The project contributes to Latino representation by focusing on a regional context that is not always central in discussions of Latinidad in Canada. Instead of concentrating on larger metropolitan centres only, the project studies the London-Sarnia corridor as a dispersed geography of Latino life.

This matters because Latino experience in Southwestern Ontario may be shaped by commuting, work, study, service industries, family networks, temporary movement, settlement, and transnational memory. The project gives visual form to this complexity without claiming to represent all Latino people.

9.4 Contribution to decolonial and ethical design practice

The project contributes to decolonial design by questioning universal standards, centering situated knowledge, and building methods of consent and participant review. It does not use decoloniality as a visual style. Instead, it asks how the process of making can challenge extraction, authorship, and institutional authority.

The project's ethical significance lies in its attention to visibility. It recognizes that representation can be empowering but also risky. By treating participants as collaborators and reviewers, the thesis proposes a more careful model for community-based typographic work.

9.5 Contribution to printmaking and material culture

The traditional printing poster series contributes to printmaking by using letterpress not as nostalgia, but as a research tool. The posters connect contemporary digital type design to historical printing technology. This creates a dialogue between new media alphabets and older systems of mechanical reproduction.

The project also contributes to material culture by showing how printed objects can carry memory, labour, and place. A poster is not only an image. It is paper, pressure, ink, edition, circulation, wall presence, and archive.

9.6 What the project adds

The project adds:

- A situated model for co-designed typography with Latino communities in Southwestern Ontario.
 - A critical framework for questioning typographic quality, cultural recognition, and material translation.
 - A material method for translating digital type systems into traditional printed posters.
 - A visual ecology approach to studying corridor life.
 - A reflexive method for ethical visibility and representation.
 - A body of work that links type design, printmaking, new media, and community-based research.
-

Section 10: Other issues to identify. Diagrams and working structures

10.1 Positionality

The thesis should include a clear positionality statement. Because the project involves Latino life, community representation, and personal cultural connection, I need to explain my relationship to the work. I am not outside the project. My background, training, language, migration experience, design education, and relationship to Latin American visual culture all shape the research.

A positionality statement should address:

- Why this project matters to me.
- How I relate to Latino life in Southwestern Ontario.
- What forms of access or trust I may have.
- What assumptions I bring as a designer.
- How my training in typography may shape what I see as good, legible, or refined.
- How I will remain accountable to participants.

10.2 Authorship and credit

The project must define authorship carefully. Since the character set is co-designed, it should not present all decisions as mine alone. However, it also needs to be clear that I am responsible for the final design, thesis framing, and exhibition.

Possible credit language:

- “Expanded Latin character set designed by Daniel Achig-Aranha through participant-informed workshops and visual research with Latino residents along the London-Sarnia corridor.”
- “Participant references and words used with consent.”
- “Some participant contributions anonymized by request.”
- “This project does not claim to represent all Latino communities in Southwestern Ontario.”

10.3 Consent and circulation

Because fonts and posters circulate, consent must include circulation. Participants should understand that the work may appear in:

- Thesis exhibition.
- Thesis paper.
- Digital portfolio.
- Academic presentation.
- Printed posters.
- Documentation photographs.
- Future publications or grant applications, if approved.

Consent should allow participants to choose levels of visibility. Some may want to be named. Others may prefer anonymity. Some references may be used visually but not described publicly. Some may be excluded entirely.

10.4 Language and translation

Translation is not neutral. If participant material moves between languages or forms of expression, meaning may shift. The thesis should explain how translation decisions are made and whether participants can review translated text.

Questions to address:

- When should participant expressions remain in their original form?
- When should translation or explanation be provided?
- How will hybrid or informal language practices be treated?
- How will accents and diacritics be preserved?
- How will regional expressions be handled?
- Who approves translation choices?

10.5 Otavalo as a Project Reference

Otavalo is not part of the final thesis outcome, but it is an important project reference. It demonstrates my previous experience with type design, Andean textile references, monolinear construction, rhythm, printmaking, variable workflows, and exhibition display. Through Otavalo, I developed practical knowledge in translating cultural memory, material process, and visual references into letterform design.

For this thesis, Otavalo functions as a methodological precedent rather than a visual model. It shows that I already have experience working across type design, material testing, printmaking, and research-creation. However, the expanded Latin character set developed for this thesis will be a new project shaped by Latino participants along the London-Sarnia corridor.

The thesis character set should not repeat Otavalo's visual language unless the research process, participants, and corridor context justify that direction. The goal is not to apply a previous style to a new community. Instead, the project will develop a situated typographic language through participant-informed research, typographic testing, and traditional printing processes.

A useful distinction:

Otavalo as precedent: a previous typeface exploration that demonstrates my experience with type design, cultural references, printmaking, variable font thinking, and exhibition-based research-creation.

Thesis character set as situated outcome: a new expanded Latin character set shaped by participants, place, visual mapping, conversations, typographic testing, and material process.

10.6 Exhibition diagram

```
[Entrance]
  |
  v
Project title + central question
  |
  v
Co-design process: interviews, participant maps, sketches, consent decisions
  |
  v
Character set development: drawings, glyph proofs, spacing tests, accents
  |
  v
Traditional printing poster series: plates, proofs, final edition, material tests
  |
  v
Digital specimen or motion test: variable type, screen, rhythm, participant-informed text
  |
  v
Reflection area: what typography can archive, what remains unresolved
```

10.7 Evidence matrix

Thesis claim	Evidence in exhibition	Evidence in paper
Typography can function as archive	Character set, maps, process archive, posters	Chapter on typography as testimony and record
Good typography is culturally situated	Participant feedback, annotated proofs	Chapter on power, standards, and typographic quality
Typographic mechanics require testing	Paragraph proofs, accent tests, specimens, posters	Chapter on mechanics, expanded Latin characters, and situated reading
Visibility requires ethics	Consent structure, anonymized references, review process	Chapter on ethical visibility and non-extraction
Place shapes typography	Visual ecology wall, route maps, corridor references	Chapter on London-Sarnia as lived geography
Material process changes meaning	Printed posters, plates, proofs, material tests	Chapter on printmaking, materiality, and archive

10.8 Working timeline

Phase	Focus	Main outputs
Phase 1	Literature review and ethics planning	Refined research questions, consent structure, bibliography
Phase 2	Participant recruitment and interviews	Interview summaries, visual maps, reference archive
Phase 3	Character set development	Sketches, glyph set, spacing proofs, typographic tests
Phase 4	Participant review and workshops	Annotated proofs, feedback, revisions
Phase 5	Traditional printing prepress	Poster designs, plate files, paper and ink plan
Phase 6	Supervised letterpress production	Proofs, editioned posters, process documentation
Phase 7	Exhibition design	Installation plan, labels, documentation, digital specimen
Phase 8	Thesis writing and analysis	Final paper, bibliography, appendices, reflection

10.9 Possible thesis chapter structure

1. **Introduction: New media alphabets and Latino life in Southwestern Ontario**
Introduce the project, central question, context, methodology, and outputs.
 2. **Typography as archive**
Discuss type as evidence, testimony, memory, and reproducible cultural form.
 3. **Against universal good typography**
Examine power, standards, professionalism, typographic quality, and participant-informed criteria.
 4. **Typographic mechanics and situated reading**
Analyze the expanded Latin character set, accents, diacritics, paragraph texture, and print/screen differences.
 5. **Ethical visibility and co-authorship**
Address consent, representation, circulation, authorship, anonymity, and refusal.
 6. **Corridor life as visual ecology**
Discuss the London-Sarnia corridor, movement, labour, signs, domestic spaces, and visual memory.
 7. **Making the expanded Latin character set**
Explain type design process, specimens, variable font testing, and participant feedback.
 8. **Printing the archive: traditional printing and letterpress posters**
Analyze the poster process, material translation, pressure, editioning, and exhibition.
 9. **Conclusion**
Summarize contributions, limitations, and future possibilities.
-

Section 11: Bibliography

The following bibliography includes relevant non-pending sources from the current thesis research list and Assignment 6 materials. Some full publication details should be verified before final thesis submission.

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Appendix A: Traditional printing and letterpress poster process as research evidence

Process material	Research value	Possible exhibition use
Digital poster file	Shows composition, hierarchy, and prepress translation	Display as small process print or screen view
Plate or plate proof	Shows conversion from font to relief printing surface	Display as object or photograph
Paper tests	Shows how material changes ink, edge, and impression	Wall grid of test samples
Ink tests	Shows colour, density, mood, and clarity	Annotated proof sheet
Registration proofs	Shows alignment, error, repetition, and correction	Process archive table
Rejected prints	Shows material resistance and decision-making	Archive drawer or process wall
Final edition	Public work and thesis output	Framed or pinned poster series
Reflection notes	Connects making to theory	Excerpted captions or thesis appendix

Appendix B: Glossary of key terms

Expanded Latin character set: In this thesis, a designed typographic system that may include uppercase and lowercase letters, numerals, punctuation, accents, diacritics, and selected extended Latin characters shaped through participant-informed research.

Archive: A collection of records, traces, materials, stories, and works that preserve memory and make knowledge accessible. In this thesis, the archive is not only institutional. It is also lived, visual, and material.

Co-design: A collaborative design process in which participants help shape references, evaluation, meaning, and decisions.

Corridor: The London-Sarnia region understood through movement, commuting, labour, roads, community networks, and visual environments.

Cliche / printing plate: In letterpress contexts, “cliche” is usually described as a printing plate, relief plate, photopolymer plate, metal plate, or printing block.

Ethical visibility: A form of representation that considers consent, agency, naming, anonymity, circulation, and possible harm.

Research-creation: A mode of inquiry where creative practice produces knowledge together with writing, theory, and analysis.

Visual ecology: A way of understanding visual culture as part of a lived environment shaped by surfaces, movement, objects, signs, bodies, and memory.